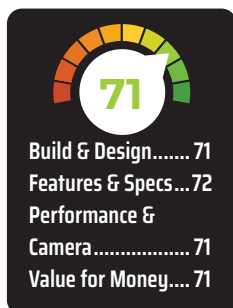


Google Pixel 8a

AI smarts and a steep price hike

The Google Pixel 8a is the latest addition to Google's smartphone lineup, positioned as a mid-range option with a focus on AI-powered features. Priced at ₹52,999, the Pixel 8a aims to provide a premium experience without reaching flagship prices. However, the question still plaguing most minds is why this phone even exists when it is so similar to the Pixel 8 and pretty close in price too. The Pixel 8a sees a massive price hike of ₹9,000 compared to its predecessor, which is huge in a price-conscious market like India. Furthermore, it competes against some heavyweights such as the iQOO 12, OnePlus 12R and of course, its own brethren, the Google Pixel 8. How will the phone fare in this competitive landscape? Is it dead on arrival or is there a niche audience that will still appreciate the phone despite its expensive price tag? Let's delve into that and more in my detailed Pixel 8a review.

₹52,999



BUILD AND DESIGN

The Pixel 8a maintains a compact form factor with a 6.1-inch display, a rarity in 2024. The phone is available in several trendy colours, including Obsidian, Porcelain, Bay, and Aloe (my personal favourite). Despite its compact size, the device is on the thicker side at 8.9mm and weighs 188 grams, which is a bit heavy compared to current standards.

The phone's design is clean and minimalistic, with a velvety smooth back finish and metal sides. The back panel looks deceptively like glass and doesn't attract fingerprints. The volume rocker and power button are on the right side, but the volume button's placement could be more ergonomic.

It includes a USB Type-C 3.2 port for charging and data transfer but lacks

a headphone jack, which is common now. The in-display fingerprint scanner performs well in most conditions. The retail box only includes a Type-A to Type-C charging cable, but there's no charging brick.

The Pixel 8a is IP67 certified, providing decent protection against dust

and water, though an IP68 rating would have been better at this price point. The use of Gorilla Glass 3 for the display is also quite disappointing, as newer generations of Gorilla Glass offer better durability.

DISPLAY

The Pixel 8a features a 6.1-inch Full HD+ display. Most importantly, it now has 120 Hz refresh rate support, a substantial upgrade over the 90 Hz display of the Pixel 7a. However, the thick bezels around the display detract from the modern aesthetic, especially considering the price range. The bezels are also not even which is disappointing since phones like the Nothing Phone (2) have shown us that it is possible

to spring for even bezels at this price. Watching videos and browsing content on the Pixel 8a is enjoyable, thanks to its vibrant colours and good contrast. The phone's display is also pretty bright. It is rated at 2,000 nits of peak brightness and in my tests, I got a reading of 1280 nits under direct sunlight in High Brightness Mode.

The display could benefit from using a higher-grade Gorilla Glass for better durability and scratch resistance. Gorilla Glass 3 is far too dated for 2024.

PERFORMANCE

Powered by the Tensor G3 chipset, the Pixel 8a offers improved performance over its predecessor. It comes with 8GB of LPDDR5X RAM and up to 256GB of UFS 3.1 storage. Thankfully, Google has chosen to offer a 256 GB model this year and not limit it to 128 GB like on the Pixel 7a, which was the need of the hour.

While the Pixel 8a performs well in day-to-day scenarios, it does suffer from occasional heating issues, particularly during intensive tasks like gaming or prolonged camera use. So, it is not a great option for power users and gamers who would have a better experience with the likes of an iQOO 12 or a OnePlus 12. This is an area where Google needs to improve, as thermal management has been a recurring issue with their Tensor-powered devices.

In benchmarks, the Pixel 8a delivers decent scores but they lag behind competition significantly. In AnTuTu v10, the Pixel 8a scores under a million while the iQOO 12 flies past it with a 2M+ score and the OnePlus 12R flaunts a 1.3M score. In GeekBench, the Pixel 8a bests the OnePlus 12R but it cannot touch the iQOO 12's score.

The phone scores 11,183 in PCMark Work which is decent enough to be competitive here. However, the phone does throttle significantly, which has been the case with the Pixels of the yesteryears too. It throttles to 66 per cent of its peak performance in just 15 minutes which is quite poor throttling performance. So, the phone does throttle significantly during intensive